

PROGRESS PAUSED

The construction of the swanky JPNIC on 18.64 acres began in Feb. 2014 and was to be completed in Oct. 2016. It was to have:

REVISED COST
₹865 cr.
(Nov. 2016)

DELAY
OVER 10 YEARS

- Open-air terrace restaurant
- Helipad on top (19th) floor
- Multi-level parking with space for 1,200 vehicles
- Seven-star guest house with 107 rooms
- Conference hall that can accommodate 1,000 people
- Olympic-sized diving pool
- Children's pool
- Tennis court
- Gymnasium
- Spa and yoga centre
- Library and a reading room in the basement
- Audio-visual museum on JP's life and times



IN PROTEST Akhilesh Yadav pays tribute to Jayaprakash Narayan in Lucknow, Oct. 11

SUMIT KUMAR

> **"The BJP is stopping us from entering JPNIC by claiming there are scorpions inside. The truth is, there are many scorpions in its own government"**
>
> **AKHILESH YADAV**
> *President, Samajwadi Party*

> **"No scheme of the Akhilesh Yadav government is untouched by corruption and the ongoing investigations have prevented the completion of these projects"**
>
> **ALOK AWASTHI** *Spokesperson, UP BJP*

the development schemes of the SP government. To divert attention from issues like unemployment and inflation in the state, it is alleging irregularities in these schemes." Awasthi argues, "No scheme of the Akhilesh government is untouched by corruption and the ongoing investigations have prevented the completion of these projects."

In 2022, the LDA decided to lease JPNIC, and several hotel groups, including the Leela Group, expressed interest. The operating cost was estimated to be Rs 100 crore under the PPP (public-private partnership) mode, but the government has yet to approve the proposal. Senior SP leader and state general secretary Jai Shankar Pandey remarks, "The BJP government is acting with political malice. If this international centre had been operational, Lucknow would have gained global recognition."

Meanwhile, due to a lack of maintenance, the JPNIC building is falling into disrepair. An official involved with its security since last August says, "The false ceiling and lights at the main gate are broken. Large flower pots once placed on both sides of the entrance are missing. Imported wood on the ramp around the swimming pool has disappeared. The aluminium and iron poles are rusting, and foam chairs in the guest house are also missing. The AC, lift, escalator and other systems in the main building are lying defunct." In July 2023, the LDA submitted a detailed report on the deteriorating condition of JPNIC to the housing department. An LDA officer says, "Maintaining JPNIC will cost Rs 70 crore annually, and